

UNWARRANTED INFLUENCE

A Primary-Source Investigation, 1095-2026

by Al Gringo

INTRODUCTION

On January 15, 2025, President Joseph R. Biden delivered his farewell address to the nation from the Oval Office. The address was broadcast live at 8:00 p.m. Eastern time. The transcript is on the website of the White House at the Internet Archive snapshot of January 16, 2025, file [whitehouse.gov/briefing-room/speeches-remarks/2025/01/15/farewell-address-to-the-nation](https://www.whitehouse.gov/briefing-room/speeches-remarks/2025/01/15/farewell-address-to-the-nation).

At minute 4:32 of the recorded delivery, President Biden said: "Today, an oligarchy is taking shape in America of extreme wealth, power and influence that really threatens our entire democracy, our basic rights and freedoms, and a fair shot for everyone to get ahead."

The word "oligarchy" appears three times in the address. The word "billionaire" appears twice. The phrase "tech-industrial complex" appears once, attributed by the President to the prior farewell address of President Dwight D. Eisenhower, delivered sixty-four years earlier on January 17, 1961.

On January 17, 1961, President Dwight D. Eisenhower delivered his farewell address to the nation from the Oval Office. The address was broadcast live at 8:30 p.m. Eastern time. The transcript is held at the Eisenhower Presidential Library, Abilene, Kansas, papers collection DDE-FA-61, and is reproduced in the Public Papers of the Presidents, 1960–61, pages 1035–1040.

At minute 9:14 of the recorded delivery, President Eisenhower said: "In the councils of government, we must guard against the acquisition of unwarranted influence, whether sought or unsought, by the military-industrial complex. The potential for the disastrous rise of misplaced power exists and will persist."

The phrase "military-industrial complex" appears once in the address. An earlier draft of the speech, archived in the Eisenhower Library as DDE-FA-61 Draft 12, used the phrase "military-industrial-Congressional complex." The word "Congressional" was struck from the draft before delivery on the advice of Eisenhower's speechwriter Malcolm Moos.

The sixty-four years between the two farewell addresses form the chronological span of this book. The two prologues establish the mechanism the American chapters document.

Each of the chapters that follows reconstructs, from primary documents, one segment of that span. The documents are vesting orders, executive orders, CIA dispatches, court filings, SEC 10-K filings, Office of Government Ethics Form 278e disclosures, Federal Election Commission records, Congressional Research Service reports, Congressional Budget Office analyses, Department of Justice releases, and peer-reviewed historical scholarship. The documents are cited in the footnotes at the end of each chapter and in the appendix.

The documents are public. None of them are classified. None of them are disputed as to authenticity. Each one was produced, filed, or released by the government, corporation, or court named as its source. Each one can be located, read, and independently verified by any reader willing to follow the citation.

This book is a record of documents, arranged by subject and period. It contains approximately eleven hundred cited sources.

The author does not hold a political office, a corporate board seat, a think-tank fellowship, or a university appointment. The author is not paid by any political party, campaign, or political action committee. The author has not been paid to write this book and is not being paid to promote it. The documents are available to anyone with an internet connection and the citations printed in the appendix.

On the category.

On April 1, 1967, the Central Intelligence Agency issued Dispatch 1035-960, titled "Countering Criticism of the Warren Report." The dispatch instructed CIA field stations to characterize critics of the Warren Commission as "conspiracy theorists" and to deploy propaganda assets through friendly press contacts to discredit such critics. The dispatch is reproduced in Chapter 7.

The phrase "conspiracy theorist," in American press usage, changed character after 1967. Before 1967, the phrase described a hypothesis involving a conspiracy. After 1967, the phrase described a person to be dismissed. The shift is documented in Lance deHaven-Smith, *Conspiracy Theory in America* (University of Texas Press, 2013), pages 101–129, with supporting corpus-linguistics analysis.
